



» TOURNAMENT PREVIEW I-LEAGUE

Title tussle: The upcoming season will miss the legacy of Churchill Brothers (facing page) — last year's provisional champion that lost a Court of Arbitration hearing and had to concede the title and promotion to Inter Kashi (above). Churchill will instead continue its battle in court, having taken the case against the AIFF to the Delhi High Court. AIFF MEDIA

A fresh kick-off

The rebranding of the I-League signals a bold attempt to **restore relevance** to a tournament long overshadowed by the ISL.

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Signings were completed and teams were assembled to get the ball rolling in the I-League as early as October last year. But the uncertainty around the Indian Super League had a trickle-down effect. From October, the league was pushed to November before being indefinitely put on hold.

Time and again, the I-League has been meted out the 'lil bro' treatment by its own federation, the All India Football Federation (AIFF), and the ISL. In the last decade alone, the league lost its top-division status, its legacy teams and star players to the ISL.

With the aim of holding its own, the I-League owners have come together to give a makeover to the second-division league, which will make its return on February 21.

The league will be rechristened as the Indian Football League, while also undergoing a new ownership model with the participating clubs owning 60 per cent stake. The incoming new commercial partner for the league will own 30 per cent, with the Federation holding the remaining 10 per cent.

"There has been negativity surrounding the I-League, so we wanted to usher in a new era," says Arshad Shawl, the owner of Real Kashmir FC, regarding the decision to rebrand the league. "We wanted to give it shape and structure. This has been a league that's been around for many years, this is the league that